



KOLKATA | No Alternative Again

How's that for gratitude? Despite Pranab Mukherjee's stellar role in the formation of the Congress-Trinamool Congress alliance in West Bengal, multiple contenders are eyeing Pranab's post of Pradesh Congress Committee (PCC) chief. If Pranab does decide to hand over charge, it will be hard for the Congress to find someone to fill his shoes ahead of the crucial Corporation polls just months away. Even though leadership change at the head of the PCC is a dim prospect, state Vice-President Manas Bhunia and the two working presidents, Subrata Mukherjee and Pradip Bhattacharya, are waiting in the wings. The rank and file, however, continue to gaze in the finance minister's direction for his undisputed PCC leadership, even though he is mostly occupied with national duties. State Mahila Congress chief Maitreyi Saha says, "There seems to be no alternative to Pranab. Nobody here knows the perfect Congress balancing act as well as he does." While most party members support Pranab, General Secretary Shanker Singh, known for his opposition to the alliance with the Trinamool Congress, claims that the Congress has ceased to exist in West Bengal. "Mamata used our cash, our helicopters and finally, Sonia and Rahul Gandhi. In return, we got nothing," he says. Pranab will only say enigmatically, "Who will succeed me is in the realm of speculation." There is no alternative, again?

by Abhijit Dasgupta

**MUKHERJEE'S
REPLACEMENT
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The number of Lok Sabha seats won by the Congress in West Bengal in the 2009 elections, identical to their 2004 poll tally.